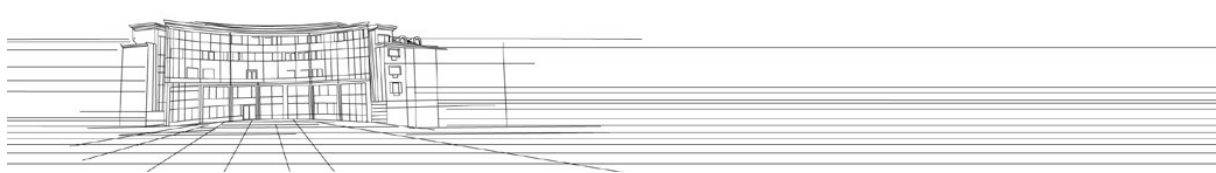


SF2323 Applied qualitative research methods, problems and design

Course Guide Fall 2025



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Course introduction

Many problems and research questions of relevance for social scientists require a qualitative design and the collection, analysis, and interpretation of qualitative data. *Applied qualitative research methods, problems and design* is developed with the ambition to provide knowledge and insights as regards how a qualitative study can best be designed and conducted. The course thus covers such issues as: “What kind of research problem requires a qualitative design?;” “What is a good qualitative research question?;” “What ethical concerns should be taken into account when conducting qualitative research?;” “What does being critical to one’s sources mean in practice?;” “How can a qualitative study be designed?;” “What is a process-tracing approach?;” and; “What are the different qualitative methods available and how can they be used in an academically correct and useful manner?” An applied focus guides the course, with practical examples being at the center stage for the discussion.

The course provides knowledge regarding qualitative methods, problems, and design and offers practical training in qualitative methodological approaches relevant to the fields of Political Science, Sociology, International Administration and Global Governance, as well as European Studies.

Course structure

The course is divided into three modules: Module 1) *Research questions, research design, and research ethics*; Module 2) *Data collection, analysis, and interpretation* (interviews, observations, typology analysis, and discourse analysis), and; Module 3) *Research plan*.

In modules 1-2, introductory lectures are followed by assignments where students apply the different themes discussed. In module 3, the introductory lecture is followed by scheduled individual and group supervision.

The structure of the course offers the students the opportunity to gain knowledge about qualitative research methods in general, but also to get hands-on experience of the strengths and weaknesses of different qualitative techniques. Students work individually as well as

together in groups, which facilitate peer-learning. Assignments are discussed in teacher-led small group seminars. The course ends with a research plan, in which the students focus on a qualitative research design and methodology of relevance for a research question of their own choice.

Module 1: Research questions, research design, and research ethics

Research methodology is a means to achieve a certain goal; to answer a specific research question. The choice of technique for data-collection (for example, whether to do interviews, text analysis, or a combination) depends on the question asked. The same goes for choice of design. Moreover, independently of the question in focus, potential ethical concerns must be taken into consideration. Module 1 focuses on the early phases of the research process, with an emphasis on how to pose theoretically and empirically relevant research questions. It also introduces a comparative approach to research, which allows you to trace causal processes, and within the framework of which the theory testing and development is the focus.

Module 1 is concluded in the assignment *Research Question and Design*, which is a group-based written and oral assignment, graded on a Fail/Pass scale (see Canvas for further instructions).

Module 2: Data collection, analysis, and interpretation

In this second module of the course students will gain theoretical as well as practical knowledge as regards how to work with qualitative data and material. Module 2 is divided into two main blocks. Each of these blocks in turn focuses on two different methods for data collection, analysis, and interpretation. *Block I* focuses on interviews and observations, whereas *Block II* focuses on typology analysis and discourse analysis.

Each block follows the same rhythm with introductory lectures followed by oral and written group assignments. Students are strongly encouraged to attend the lectures given in both blocks. However, when it comes to the oral and written group assignments, students are only required to take part in one of the assignments for each block. That is, in terms of *Block I*, students are required to take part either in the assignment on interviews or in the assignment on observations, and in terms of *Block II*, students are required to take part either in the assignment on typology analysis or in the assignment on discourse analysis. In other words: students have a choice between observations and interviews on the one hand, and, on the other hand, typology analysis and discourse analysis.

Module 2 sums up in total two assignments: the assignment *Interviews* **or** the assignment *Observations* and the assignment *Typology Analysis* **or** the assignment *Discourse analysis*. These are all group-based written and oral assignments, graded on a Fail/Pass scale (see Canvas for further instructions).

Module 3: Research proposal

The third and final module gives the students an opportunity to show their methodological skills and start thinking about, as well as start writing on, their master's thesis. Module 3 sums up in a *Research proposal*, which is an individual oral as well as written assignment, graded on a Fail/Pass/High Pass scale. The research plan should be maximum 4000 words, exclusive of the reference list (see Canvas for further instructions).

Learning outcomes

The purpose of the course is to stimulate the students to acquire the knowledge, skills, and judgment necessary in order to be able to critically assess others' research as well as design a research project of their own. After completing the course, the students are expected to be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

- Demonstrate general methodological knowledge and understanding of the various steps of the research process, namely problem formulation, theory, design, data collection and analysis.
- Demonstrate in-depth methodological knowledge in the main areas of qualitative method such as comparative case studies, observations, interviews and various forms of text analysis.
- Demonstrate knowledge of source-critical problems in qualitative research.
- Demonstrate knowledge of basic theoretical positions in science.
- Demonstrate knowledge of research ethics aspects that are relevant to qualitative research.

Competence and skills

- Demonstrate an in-depth ability to distinguish the different steps of the research process – i.e. problem formulation, theory, design, data collection and analysis – and how the different steps of the research process relate to each other.
- Demonstrate in-depth ability to design and plan a qualitative study.
- Demonstrate in-depth ability to carry out comparative case studies, observations, interviews and various forms of text analysis in a way that is adequate for the social sciences.
- Demonstrate the ability to apply source criticism in a way relevant to qualitative research.
- Independently produce text in accordance with good academic standards, including correct citation techniques and reference management.
- Express themselves orally and in writing in good and comprehensible English.

Judgement and approach

- Identify and assess ethical issues that are relevant to qualitative research.
- Evaluate how the choice of method and design is affected by problem formulation and theoretical points of departure.
- Critically evaluate how the choices that are made enable or limit the conclusions that can be drawn from a study.

Examination, grading and assignments

The examination on the course consists of a number of written as well as oral assignments:

- Assignment 1: Research Question and Design
 - Group-based written and oral assignment, graded on a Fail/Pass (see Canvas for further instructions).
- Assignment 2a: Interviews **or** Assignment 2b: Observations
 - Group-based written and oral assignment, graded on a Fail/Pass scale (see Canvas for further instructions).
- Assignment 3a: Typology Analysis **or** Assignment 3b: Discourse Analysis

- Group-based written and oral assignment, graded on a Fail/Pass scale (see Canvas for further instructions).
- Assignment 4: Research Proposal
 - Individual written and oral assignment (research proposal), graded on a Fail/Pass/High Pass scale (see Canvas for further instructions).

Assignments are uploaded on Canvas (see folders under each module and/or block). All assignments need to include the name (s) of the student(s), the course code SF2323 and the heading Assignment 1, Assignment 2a or Assignment 2b, Assignment 3a or Assignment 3b, and Assignment 4, respectively. Please make sure that the paper follows the guidelines of the specific assignment and is uploaded in the correct folder!

Remember that correct academic writing (good structure and grammar, proper language, correctly entered references, etc.) is a basic requirement that your assignments need to fulfil in order to be considered for grading at all.

The compositions of the groups for the group assignments on Research Question and Design will be randomly selected. We do this because we think it is fairer than letting the students themselves choose and we also think that it can be seen as part of the education to learn how to work together with other students in different constellations. The group compositions will be published on Canvas.

The students will be able to choose between doing the assignment on Interviews or the assignment on Observations as well as between doing the assignments on Typology Analysis or the assignment on Discourse Analysis. The compositions of the groups for these assignments will be randomly selected after all students have chosen which assignments to work with. The group compositions will be handled on Canvas.

Participation is mandatory at all seminars. Those students who fail to participate (e.g. those who do not participate actively as assigned, arrive late, do not stay throughout the whole seminar, or do not show up at all) will need to write another two pages discussing one of the seminar assignments presented by the other groups. These two extra pages are written individually and uploaded on Canvas in the specific folder *Late Assignments*. Late assignments will not be discussed in a seminar.

If your group misses a deadline, or fail a written seminar assignment, you need to upload a new version of the paper on Canvas in the specific folder for Late Assignments. Dates for failed and/or late assignments will be published on canvas.

For a *Pass* on the course, the student needs to have a Pass on all required assignments (i.e. Assignment 1, Assignment 2a or 2b, Assignment 3a or 3b, and Assignment 4). For a *High Pass* on the course, the student needs to have – in addition to having a Pass on Assignments 1, 2a or 2b, 3a or 3b – a High Pass on Assignment 4 (Research Plan).

As for the qualitative criteria for grading, while both a Pass and a High Pass require that the answers provided are well in line with the assignment, correct, and that the discussion follows a clear red thread, a High Pass in addition requires an independent and analytical approach.

Academic Writing

The three hallmarks of good academic writing are clarity, precision, and intellectual honesty. Unlike some other forms of writing, academic texts should be free from ambiguity, and they should offer the reader plainly stated arguments, not rhetorical tricks. This does not mean that they have to be boring, of course, but it does mean that, whenever there is a conflict between being linguistically elegant and clear, the latter should take precedence. For example, in academic writing, it might be preferable to consistently use the same terms for the same concepts instead of using synonyms, even though this would be dull in other types of writing (such as fiction). To organize the text, a good rule of thumb is to make one point per paragraph.

Good academic writing is cumulative; it proceeds from, communicates with, and seeks to contribute to previous work on the topic of choice. It is essential that the author (or authors) gives due credit to previous work. There should never be any doubt as to whether segments of text, ideas, claims or results are the author's own or drawn from other sources. To ensure this, academic writing requires a transparent system of citation. Never 'copy and paste' text from other sources without citing those sources and enclosing direct quotes in quotation marks. Copying text without indicating it is a quotation constitutes plagiarism. Use references consistently and accurately. These requirements hold for all academic texts, from short student assignments and course papers to master theses and academic books and journal articles.

At the University of Gothenburg, we take academic integrity very seriously. You will find all the information and relevant links regarding this and other important matters on *Canvas*. See also the sections on *AI policy* and *Attempts to deceive during examinations* below.

AI policy

AI is a widely used technology designed to generate unique outputs in response to natural language inputs called prompts. Text-generating apps such as ChatGPT (OpenAI), Copilot (Microsoft), and Gemini (Google) draw from large language models containing vast amounts of data curated from the internet and use text prediction algorithms to generate fluent, human-like outputs.

On this course, the A -policy is divided into Permitted, Problematic, and Prohibited Use.

Permitted: You are allowed to use AI for personalized support, e.g. to ask for instructions to carry out a specific task or use a tool, e.g. how to create a figure/graph, or to provide an example of how an academic paper can be structured.

Problematic: If you want language support, please use rule-based AI apps designed to find and correct textual errors. An even better option is to sign up for an advising session at the Unit of Academic Language (ASK).

Prohibited Use: You are not allowed to use AI for text generation or content revision! Learning occurs during the writing process. By reading, thinking, writing, analyzing and explaining your thoughts and arguments, you deepen your knowledge, memorize the important issues and learn skills. A chatbot will jeopardize your ability to develop your knowledge and skills. It is moreover considered a form of attempt to deceive during examination and will thus be treated as a case of such (see below).

Students should submit an AI declaration for all written assignments.

Students who do use AI:

- Which apps you used
- How you used the apps
- Why you used the apps

Students who do not use GenAI:

- Statement of non-use
- Explanation of non-use

Attempts to deceive during examinations

An attempt to deceive during examination means that a student has attempted to give an impression of their performance in a written exam or some of form of assessment that is not true. That is what is commonly referred to as cheating. There are different kinds of attempts to deceive, such as plagiarism, prohibited aids and prohibited collaboration.

- Plagiarism means that a student presents someone else's text or other material as if it was their own text or material.
- Prohibited aid means that a student has used aids, including AI, that were not permitted according to the instructions.
- Prohibited collaboration means that students have collaborated with each other in breach of the instructions.

Deception can also take other forms.

All submitted student work is screened with a program called Ouriginal, which compares a student's written work with published materials (including everything published on the internet) and all the work from prior students, to detect plagiarism. The material you have read and based your arguments and factual statements on should always be referenced using proper referencing technique.

Any kind of cheating on examinations is considered a serious offence. Proved or suspected cheating will be reported to the Disciplinary Committee of the University of Gothenburg, in accordance with the procedure of disciplinary matters at the department of political science.

The consequences may be severe for a student if found guilty. A student may be suspended from classes and campus for a determined time-period (from 3 weeks to half a year), which will result in a temporary suspension of all financial aid (including CSN) and may jeopardize a student's residence permit status. More information on disciplinary matters, including plagiarism and its consequences, can be found here: <https://studentportal.gu.se/en/your-studies/exams/cheating-during-examinations?>

Course evaluation

The students will be given the opportunity to fill in a course evaluation. The results of the evaluation, and subsequent possible changes to the course, will be shared with students who participated in the evaluation as well as future students who will take the course the following years. Course reports are published on Canvas.

Equal treatment

The University of Gothenburg aims to promote equal rights and opportunities for all students and employees and to combat discrimination related to gender, gender identity or gender expressions, ethnicity, religion or other beliefs, sexual orientation, disability or age. If you as a student at the Department of Political Science become subject to such acts and actions, we encourage you to contact us to enable the opportunity for appropriate action. You can contact: the course coordinator, director of studies Linda Berg, or student counselor Eva Nilsson. Student counselors have confidentiality. You can also turn to these persons if you experience problems or discomfort in the study environment, even if not targeted at you. All contact information is available on our website.